

_Complete Integrated Core Rules

PART 1: THE PROTAGONIST

1. Attributes and Roles

Every Protagonist is defined by three Attributes, rated from **0 to 12**. Attributes have distinct mechanical functions divided strictly between Combat and Roleplay.

Attribute	Combat Role	Roleplay & Narrative Role
Body	Max HP, Movement distance, Mitigate defense, Melee attacks.	Physical feats (strength, parkour), Senses (vision, hearing).
Mind	Healing Threshold, Dodge defense, Ranged attacks.	Reactions, problem-solving, intelligence, charisma, hacking.
Soul	Manifestation abilities, Augments, Luck Dice pool.	Empathy, memory retention, supernatural perception.

Attribute Brackets:

For combat scaling, non-combat dice pools, weapon tiers, and defense tiers, Attributes are grouped into brackets:

- **0–4:** Tier 1 (Entry / Dump-stat)
- **5–8:** Tier 2 (Mid-tier)
- **9–12:** Tier 3 (High-tier)

2. Level and Advancement

Your overall character Level is derived from your total Attribute points.

$$\text{Level} = (\text{Body} + \text{Mind} + \text{Soul}) \div 3, \text{ rounded down. (Maximum Level is 12).}$$

Currencies:

- **Attribute Points (AP):** Earned from milestones. 1 AP raises one Attribute by 1.
- **Mnemonic Points (MP):** Earned from missions. Used to purchase skills, techniques, and enhancements.

Learning Abilities:

There are two ways to learn an ability:

- **Imprint:** Pay the listed MP cost to learn the ability instantly.
- **Realize:** Fulfill the narrative unlock condition during play to learn it for free. (You may always bypass narrative conditions by paying the MP).

Archetypes:

Each Archetype provides one combat passive, one narrative passive, and four signature abilities. You choose one signature ability at Levels 1, 3, and 6. The unchosen fourth ability remains locked unless the Conductor allows it to be *Realized* later for a major cost.

3. Luck Dice (Soul)

Soul governs your luck. You regain all Luck Dice at the start of each session.

- **Soul 0–2:** 1 Die | **Soul 3–5:** 2 Dice | **Soul 6–8:** 3 Dice | **Soul 9–11:** 4 Dice | **Soul 12:** 5 Dice

Spending Luck Dice:

Spend 1 Luck Die to reroll one die, OR add one die of the same type to an attack roll, defense roll, or skill check.

- **Limits:** Normally, only 1 Luck Die may be spent per roll. You may spend a Luck Die to add a die to an Attribute check only if the pool is below 6d6. You may *always* spend a Luck Die to reroll a die, even at the cap.

PART 2: CORE RESOLUTION (SKILL CHECKS)

1. Dice Pools and Derived Stats

Skill checks use d6 dice pools determined by the relevant Attribute's bracket:

- **0–4 Score:** 1d6
- **5–8 Score:** 2d6
- **9–12 Score:** 3d6

(The absolute maximum skill check pool is 6d6. Only one skill bonus applies to a check unless explicitly stated).

Derived Checks:

Update these only when core Attributes change. **Derived Score = (Attr 1 + Attr 2) ÷ 2, rounded down.**

- **Grit (Body + Mind):** Stealth, crafting, parkour, manual rigging.
- **Aura (Body + Soul):** Performance, intimidation, commanding presence.
- **Will (Mind + Soul):** Deception, insight, resisting mental/AR intrusion.

2. Reading the Dice and Explosions

Roll the pool and read each d6 separately.

- **1–3:** 0 Hits
- **4–5:** 1 Hit
- **6:** 1 Hit + Explode

Explosion Rules: If a die shows a 6, count 1 Hit, then reroll that die. If the new result is 4+, gain another Hit. If the new result is another 6, it explodes again.

Difficulty:

- **Easy:** 1 Hit | **Medium:** 2 Hits | **Hard:** 3 Hits | **Extreme:** 4+ Hits

3. Versus Checks and Tie-Breakers

When both sides roll, compare total Hits.

- If both sides are Protagonists, the defender wins ties.
- If there is no defender, the side with the higher relevant Attribute wins.
- If still tied, both succeed, or the Conductor chooses the most dramatic outcome.

4. Critical Success (RETCON)

If 2 or more dice in your pool show a natural 6 *before* explosions, you earn a **RETCON**.

A RETCON allows you to change one fictional detail before the end of the session, provided it is not outrageous (Conductor approval required). Only one RETCON is available per session per player and is removed at session end.

5. Attribute Mastery Skills

Mastery unlocks automatically based on individual Attribute scores, not character Level.

- **Score 2 (Intention):** *Exhaust (once per scene)* — Reroll any number of 1s on a check using this Attribute.
- **Score 6 (Precision):** *Exhaust* — Replace one die with a 5 on a check using this Attribute.
- **Score 10 (Prowess):** *Once per session* — Turn one die into a natural 6 on a check using this Attribute. This die will explode.

(Limits are tracked separately per Attribute. For Derived checks, you may use a Mastery Skill from either involved Attribute. Only one may be declared after rolling).

PART 3: THE COMBAT ROUND

1. Round Structure and The Spotlight

Each round has three steps: **Player Phase**, **Enemy Phase**, and **Cleanup**.

Within a phase, there is no fixed turn order. Combat uses the **Spotlight**:

- The Protagonist with the highest Mind starts with the Spotlight (players choose on a tie).
- Whoever has the Spotlight spends their Beats, moves, or hands the Spotlight to another participant who still has Beats.
- Handing off the Spotlight does *not* refresh abilities or limits.
- Players are free to bounce Spotlight between them at will, a player may receive Spotlight only if they have at least 1 Beat.
- **Ambush**: If the Conductor declares an ambush, Round 1 starts with the Enemy Phase. Surprised Protagonists cannot use *Swift* or *Cadence* reactions during that Phase.

2. Beats and Action Costs

Each Protagonist has **2 Beats per round**. Unused Beats are lost.

- **Free (0 Beats)**: Switch equipped weapons, reload (no ammo tracking), open a door, speak a short sentence, spend movement tiles.
- **1 Beat**: Basic attack, Lesser Manifestation, use an item, draw a weapon, stabilize an ally, Hide.
- **2 Beats**: Chain Attack, Greater Manifestation, powerful Technique, complex action.

Action Keywords & Limits:

- **Commitment**: You cannot attack the same target more than once per round *unless* you Chain. (AoE attacks commit you to every Being directly affected. Splash damage does not).
- **Swift**: A reaction to a trigger. You may only use *one* Swift reaction per round.
- **Cadence**: Usable once per round.
- **Exhaust**: Usable once per scene/combat.
- **Tag**: Activates during a Spotlight handoff (requires receiving player's agreement).

3. Movement, Positioning, and Terrain

Movement does not cost Beats.

Movement Pool = 6 + Body in tiles.

You may split movement freely before, between, or after actions. *There is no Dash action.* Tiles are guidelines for positioning, not a cage; the Conductor should allow stylish action (wall-runs, slides) if the tile cost is paid.

- **Jumping:** Freely jump a gap up to your Body score. Exceeding this requires a check, a Beat, or finding a new route.
- **Range Bands:** Melee (Adjacent tiles), Short (Up to 3 tiles), Medium (Up to 6 tiles), Long (Up to 9 tiles), Very Long (Up to 12 tiles). Includes your tile and all tiles up to the max.
- **Terrain:** Difficult terrain costs 2 Movement per tile. Obstacles may provide full obstruction (blocks line of sight).
- **Forced Movement:** Pushed/pulled Beings move in a straight line. If pushed into an obstacle or another Being: stop, take 5 Entropy damage. (Against Mooks, this deals 1 Harm).
- **Fall Damage:** Falls greater than 3 tiles deal 1 Melee damage per additional 1 tile. (Counts as an Attack Value that can be defended against).

4. Hidden

A Hidden Being cannot be directly targeted by attacks requiring line of sight.

To hide:

1. Break line of sight or be heavily obscured.
2. Spend 1 Beat.
3. Win a Grit clash against the highest Body of any enemy that could observe you. (If none are observing, Conductor calls for a Medium Grit check).

Breaking Hidden: Making an attack, casting a Manifestation, or becoming clearly visible.

Benefit: Your first attack from Hidden gives you **+10 AV**.

PART 4: EQUIPMENT & ATTACK RULES

1. Loadout and Quality

You have **1 equipped Basic Melee weapon**, **1 equipped Basic Ranged weapon**, **1 equipped Basic Armor**, and **3 Inventory Slots**.

- Switching equipped weapons is Free. Drawing different weapons or other items from Inventory costs 1 Beat.

- Weapons and Armor have tags: Legal (openly carried), Restricted (permit required), or Illegal (black-market; open use raises Infamy).

Quality (Physical item scaling):

- **Basic:** +0 Bonus | 1 Upgrade Slot
- **Refined:** +5 Bonus | 2 Upgrade Slots
- **Masterpiece:** +10 Bonus | 3 Upgrade Slots

2. Weapon Tiers and Attack Value (AV)

Your Attack Value combines your character's combat Tier (determined by your Attribute Bracket) with your weapon's physical Quality.

Weapon Tier Dice:

Melee uses your Body bracket; Ranged uses your Mind bracket. By design, Melee rolls larger dice (d8) than Ranged (d6).

- **Bracket 0–4 (Tier 1):** Melee rolls **1d8** | Ranged rolls **1d6**
- **Bracket 5–8 (Tier 2):** Melee rolls **2d8** | Ranged rolls **2d6**
- **Bracket 9–12 (Tier 3):** Melee rolls **3d8** | Ranged rolls **3d6**

Attack Value (AV) = Weapon Tier Dice + Quality Bonus + Chaining Factor (if Chaining).

Open Information: The Conductor must state the enemy's defense value before you roll an attack. Likewise, when an enemy attacks, the Conductor states the AV before you choose your defense.

3. Combat Critical Hits

Combat rolls use explosive dice. If any die in an Attack, Mitigate, or Dodge roll shows its natural maximum:

Roll one additional die of the same size and add the new result.

4. Attack Tie Rules

If an attack exactly equals a defense:

- PC Defender vs NPC Attacker: PC wins (0 Damage).

- PC Attacker vs NPC Defender: PC wins.
- If Attacker wins ONLY because of a tie:
 - Against Mitigate: Deals exactly 1 damage before Resistance.
 - Against Dodge: Counts as a Glancing Blow.
 - Against Mooks: Deals 1 Harm.

5. Chaining (2 Beats)

A Chain is a combined attack against one target. You cannot Chain a weapon to itself or a Manifestation to itself.

1. Spend 2 Beats.
2. Roll your primary attack (Weapon or Manifestation) normally.
3. Choose a *different* secondary weapon or Manifestation. Add its **Chaining Factor (CF)** to the roll.
4. **Melee Momentum:** If the follow-up attack is Melee, you may move up to 3 tiles for *free* between the primary and follow-up attack, for the purpose of ending in Melee range.
5. **Secondary Effects:** The secondary source adds its damage type and its effect if the attack connects.

Chaining Factor (CF) Calculation:

This can be ignored as most are already precalculated, however:

If an item has no printed CF: **CF = floor(Maximum Possible Non-Exploding Value ÷ 2) – Penalty.**

Exclude situational bonuses and CF itself.

- Max possible 1–19 = Penalty 1
- Max possible 20–29 = Penalty 2
- Max possible 30–39 = Penalty 3

Example: *Nathan Chains his Tier 2 Refined Ranged weapon (2d6 + 5) into his Tier 2 Basic Melee weapon (2d10 + 0). He rolls his Ranged AV normally. The Melee weapon's max non-exploding value is 20. $20 \div 2 = 10$. Minus the Penalty of 2 (for the 20-29 bracket) = CF 8. Nathan adds 8 to his Ranged AV.*

PART 5: DEFENSE, HEALTH, AND STATUS

1. Defenses and Exposed

When attacked, the Conductor states the incoming AV. You have **1 Mitigate and 1 Dodge per round**. Defenses refresh at the start of your side's phase.

Like weapons, defenses scale off your Attribute brackets (Mitigate = Body, Dodge = Mind) and your equipped Armor Quality (+0 / +5 / +10). By design, Dodge rolls a larger die (d8) than Mitigate (d6).

Armor Quality applies to both Mitigate and Dodge.

Defense Tier Dice:

- **Bracket 0–4:** Mitigate rolls **1d6** | Dodge rolls **1d8**
- **Bracket 5–8:** Mitigate rolls **2d6** | Dodge rolls **2d8**
- **Bracket 9–12:** Mitigate rolls **3d6** | Dodge rolls **3d8**

Choosing a Defense:

- **Take It:** Take full AV as damage. (Spends no defense).
- **Mitigate (Body + Armor):** Roll Mitigate tier dice + Armor bonus. **Damage = AV – MDV.** (Minimum damage 0).
- **Dodge (Mind + Armor):** Roll Dodge tier dice + Armor bonus.
 - *Total Success (DDV > AV):* 0 Damage.
 - *Glancing Blow (Fail by 1–5):* Take half AV, rounded down.
 - *Full Hit (Fail by 6+):* Take full AV.
- **All-In Defense:** Sacrifice your Dodge to gain +5 to Mitigate for one attack (or vice versa). Both are spent afterward.

Exposed:

If you have spent both Mitigate and Dodge, you are Exposed. Further attacks land automatically for full damage; no defense roll is made.

Defensive Burn:

If Exposed, you may accept 1 **Burn Token** to immediately roll Mitigate or Dodge against one attack (Max 2 Burns at all times). *Penalty:* At the start of your next turn, you lose 1 Beat per Burn Token. Tokens clear at the end of that round.

2. Damage Types and Modifiers

1. Calculate base AV.
2. **Weakness**: Attack gains +5 AV.
3. Resolve defense roll.
4. **Resistance**: Reduce AV by 5.
5. **Immunity**: No damage and no related status effects.
6. Apply final damage.

Damage Types:

- *Melee, Ranged, Arcane*: Standard.
- *Entropy (Status Effects)*: Cannot be Mitigated or Dodged. Can be Resisted/Immune.
- *Aeon (Reality Distortion)*: True damage. Ignores defense, resistance, immunity, and reduction. *(Multi-Type: Weakness and Resistance cancel out if both apply. Immunity to a secondary CF type only counts as Resistance).*

3. Status Effects (Entropy)

A Being can have only one stack of each Status Effect. Un-proc'd Status Effects are **removed at the end of the Round**.

If a second stack is applied before the round ends, the effect **PROCs** (creating a massive secondary effect) and is removed immediately.

- **Drain (Bleed/Poison)**:
 - *Standard*: Whenever the Being makes an offensive action or spends movement, it takes 5 Entropy damage.
 - *PROC*: Target takes 10 Entropy. Attacker heals 5 HP (with Overflow).
- **Burst (Volatile/Explosive)**:
 - *Standard*: At the end of the Round, take 5 Entropy damage.
 - *PROC*: Target takes 10 Entropy. All Beings in Short Range take 5 Entropy.
- **Twist (Confusion/Dizzy)**:
 - *Standard*: -5 to all Defense Values until the end of the Round.
 - *PROC*: Target's next Attack Value suffers -10. Attacker immediately gains +5 Movement.
 - The -5 to all Defense is removed as well!
(Vs Mooks: Standard = 1 Harm. Primary PROC = 2 Harm. Secondary AoE PROC = 1 Harm).

4. Health, Fading, and Deep Wounds

- **Max HP:** $10 + (\text{roll } 1d4) \times \text{Body} + \text{Enhancements}$. Damage cannot reduce you below negative Max HP.
- **Healing Threshold (HT):** $3 + \text{Mind}$. Total healing per round cannot exceed HT, unless the heal explicitly states *Overflow*. HT resets at the start of each round.

Fading (0 HP):

When HP drops to 0 or below, you enter Fading.

- You have 1 Beat per turn. Max movement is 3 tiles. You cannot Chain. You take double damage.
- You gain 1 Fading Token at the start of the Player Phase. (3 Tokens = Permanent Death).
- **Stabilize:** An ally in Short Range may spend 1 Beat to remove 1 Token. (Does not restore HP).

Deep Wound (-Max HP):

If your HP drops to -Max HP, stop there. You survive, but your constitution is fractured.

- *Effect:* In all future combats, you begin at exactly 10 HP.
- *Cure:* Only a Trauma Kit (special item) can remove a Deep Wound.

Out of Combat: Surviving Protagonists heal to full HP and clear Fading (Deep Wounds remain).

PART 6: MANIFESTATIONS

Powered by Soul, Manifestations are weaponized memories. Range is *Short* by default. Damage type is *Arcane*. Unlocked at Soul 1, 3, 5, 7, 9, and 11.

1. Types and Baselines

Key the math strictly to the Beat cost.

- **Lesser:** 1 Beat. (Baseline: 1d10, CF 4).
- **Greater:** 2 Beats. (Baseline: 2d10, CF 8).

2. Augments (Free)

Shape a Manifestation upon casting. (Limit 1 per cast, or 2 with the Specialization skill). Using a "Strong" augment applies the *Exhaust* keyword to the entire Manifestation.

PART 7: THE WORLD, ECONOMY & HAZARDS

1. The Handler and AR

Your AR lenses and earpiece link you to the city grid.

- **Grid Signal:** Strong (Full access), Weak (AR/comms work, scanning/commerce fails), None (Offline, cached data only).
- **AR Assist (Analyze Action):** Exhaust. Spend 1 Beat to scan an enemy (Mind check). Conductor reveals one weakness, resistance, hazard, or tactical trait.
- **Memory Sanctity:** Handlers cannot legally access, store, or alter personal memories. Memory crimes require illegal hardware or specific Manifestations and raise severe Infamy.
- **SafeMode:** Activates during digital attacks, Downpour, or memory distortion. AR Assist and commerce are disabled.

2. Economy & Wealth

- **Dual Currency: Syn-C** (Digital, traceable, legal). **Kaph** (Physical pre-Collapse cash, untraceable, required for black markets).
- **Rainform Rule:** During Downpour, the dome opens and Handlers lock into SafeMode. Syn-C commerce suspends. Only physical Kaph is accepted.
- **Wealth Thresholds:** Add Syn-C and Kaph together.
 - *Tight (0–999):* Track every purchase.
 - *Stable (1000–2,499):* Purchases of 25 or less are free.
 - *Flush (2,500+):* Purchases of 100 or less are free.

3. Factions & Infamy

- **Faction Standing (Per Crew):** Allied (provides intel/safehouses/gear), Neutral (standard), Hostile (sends enforcers/bounties, refuses service). Harming a faction moves them to Hostile. Once Hostile, standard favors don't work; requires major story events to fix. Killing a boss makes them instantly Hostile.
- **Infamy (0–5, Per Crew):** Measures crew's heat. Gain +1 Infamy per gig if civilians see violence, bodies are left, witnesses escape, or heavy property damage occurs.

PART 8: THE CONDUCTOR'S GUIDE

1. Conductor Best Practices

- **State Values Openly:** Always announce enemy AV, DV, range bands, and obvious hazards

before rolls are made. Do not make players guess the math.

- **Weaknesses/Resistances:** Keep these hidden until fiction makes them obvious, an AR scan reveals them, or a player succeeds on a knowledge check.
- **Movement as Permission:** If a player describes a stylish traversal (wall-run, rail-grind), allow it without a check if the tile cost is paid.
- **Objectives:** Never build a combat that is just "kill everyone." Include a ticking clock, an escape route, reinforcements, or an environmental hazard.
- **Grouping Enemies:** Roll one attack for a group of similar mooks, use static DVs, and apply Harm in batches for speed.

2. Enemy Math & Content Bands

Enemies are pre-balanced based on the players' current Attribute Bracket. Pick a Band, read across the tables, and **do not construct enemies using player rules**.

Content Band	Player Bracket	Mook DV
Early	3–5 (Tier 1)	8
Mid	6–8 (Tier 2)	14
Late	9–11 (Tier 3)	16–17
End	12 (Maxed)	21–23

- **Mooks:** Mooks track Harm, not HP. (Normal Hit = 1 Harm. Crit / PROC = 2 Harm). Reskin difficulty via Harm thresholds: *Fodder (2 Harm)*, *Standard (3 Harm)*, *Tough/Minion (4 Harm)*.
- **Elites:** Track standard HP. Usually have 2 Beats, 1 Mitigate, and 1 Dodge per round (or static values from the table).
- **Bosses:** Track standard HP. Defenses refresh once per round at the top of the round. Bosses can be Exposed, but do not Burn.
 - *Influence Value:* A counter representing boss speed (usually 2, 3, or 4). When players collectively spend Beats equal to the Influence Value, the boss immediately interrupts to take an extra turn. Reset the counter.

- *Tenacity*: Bosses can have Tenacity against status effects (e.g., immune to one type, reduces Entropy damage by 5, or ignores non-Exhaust bind effects) so they are not trivially locked down by PC PROCs.